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STUDENT HANDOUT

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Who Ruled Judaea?

Grades 5–8 · Social Studies

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ADMIT ONE

NAME _____ DATE _____ CLASS _____

In Jesus' lifetime, no single person ruled Judaea. An emperor in Rome, kings from Herod's family and Roman governors all held power there — and each of them made coins. Two thousand years later, those coins are evidence you can hold of who was in charge.

HISTORICAL METHOD

Corroboration

One source can be mistaken. A historian trusts a claim more when **independent** sources — made by different people for different reasons — agree.

PART 1

01 Test the claims

Three rulers, their coins and a second witness. What does each source add, and how strong is the claim?

RULER AND COIN	THE NEW TESTAMENT SAYS	THE SECOND WITNESS	YOUR VERDICT: WHAT DOES EACH SOURCE ADD?
 **Pontius Pilate** Prefect, 26–36 AD Coin: 29/30 AD	Pilate tries Jesus and washes his hands before the crowd (Matthew 27:24).	A limestone block inscribed with his name and title, found at Caesarea Maritima in 1961; now in the Israel Museum.	
 **Herod Agrippa I** King, 41 AD Coin: 41–44 AD	He executes James, seizes Peter, accepts divine honors from a crowd and is struck down, eaten by worms (Acts 12).	The Jewish historian Josephus (*Antiquities* 19.8.2) describes his death in almost identical terms.	
 **Claudius** Emperor, 41–54 AD Coin: bronze as	Aquila and Priscilla reach Corinth because Claudius had ordered all Jews to leave Rome (Acts 18:2).	The Roman historian Suetonius (*Claudius* 25.4) confirms the edict, dated to about 49 AD.	

02

PART 2

A detail that fits

When Festus reopened Paul's case, Paul used his right as a Roman citizen to appeal to the emperor (Acts 25:10–12). Scholars often note that this detail reflects accurate knowledge of Roman legal practice, and Festus minted coins in the years Acts describes. Is getting the **system** right good evidence that a writer got the **events** right? Explain.

03

PART 3

What can a coin prove?

Consider these facts from the exhibition:

- Some scholars once doubted Pilate existed. His coins were there before the 1961 stone: *evidence all along*.
- Pilate's coin shows pagan symbols, but it says nothing about the trial of Jesus.
- The widow's lepton, minted under King Alexander Jannaeus in 103–76 BC, was still in use a century later.
- Three coins in the exhibition are replicas, because originals are exceptionally rare.

Write an argument: **what can coins prove about the rulers of the New Testament, and what can they not prove?** Make a claim, use at least two pieces of evidence, and answer one objection.

MINI MUSEUM CONNECTION

Case 8 holds the coins of Agrippa I, Claudius and Festus: the rulers the apostles stood before. Which of the three has the strongest outside corroboration, and which depends most on Acts alone?

minimuseumproject.org/exhibitions/in-their-hands